

WORDPRESS PLUGIN · USER GUIDE

MBR Live Radio Player

A complete, illustrated guide to installing, configuring and getting the very best from your audio player.



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Licence	GPL v2 or later · free & open source
Requires	WordPress 5.2+ · PHP 7.2+ · tested to WP 6.8

Contents

- 1** Introduction
- 2** Key features at a glance
- 3** Requirements & installation
- 4** Quick start — your first station in five minutes
- 5** Creating a station
- 6** Live Stream mode
- 7** File Player mode
- 8** Player appearance & skins
- 9** The live admin preview
- 10** Shortcode reference
- 11** Multi-station switching
- 12** Pop-out player
- 13** Sticky player
- 14** Supported formats
- 15** Frequently asked questions
- 16** Troubleshooting
- 17** Privacy, data & performance
- 18** Third-party libraries
- 19** Updates & support

SECTION 1

Introduction

MBR Live Radio Player is a powerful yet straightforward WordPress plugin for embedding professional audio players on your website. Whether you are running a live internet radio station, streaming a church service, or publishing a series of podcast episodes and recordings, this plugin has you covered.

Every player is built and previewed live inside the WordPress admin. You choose your skin, set your colours, upload artwork, and see exactly what your visitors will see — before you publish a single page. There are no external services, no accounts to create, no CDNs and no tracking. Everything runs inside your own WordPress installation.

Two ways to play

The plugin operates in one of two modes per station. **Live Stream mode** connects to an internet radio stream and displays live now-playing information. **File Player mode** turns the same player into a full playlist player for audio files you host yourself. You can mix both across your site — each station is configured independently.

Who is this guide for?

Site owners and editors who want to add a radio or audio player to a page, and developers who need the shortcode and configuration reference. No coding is required for everyday use — a station is created entirely through the WordPress admin screens.

Perfect for

- Internet radio stations — AM/FM simulcast, DAB, or web-only
- Podcast publishers with an archive of episodes
- Churches streaming sermons and services
- Music venues, DJs and event streaming
- Corporate audio communications
- Audio course content and membership sites

SECTION 2

Key features at a glance

Playback

- Live radio streaming with real-time now-playing metadata and a status indicator
- Adaptive HLS (.m3u8) streaming, plus Shoutcast, Icecast and native audio formats
- File Player mode with a full playlist, progress bar and seek scrubbing
- Rewind and forward 15 seconds, and auto-advance to the next track
- Resume from the exact position a listener last left off

Appearance

- Six professionally designed skins: Default, Classic, Gradient Dark, Minimal, Retro and Slim Bar
- Custom two-colour gradient picker on the Default skin
- Dark mode and glassmorphism variants
- Station artwork via the WordPress featured image
- Fully responsive across desktop, tablet and mobile

Convenience

- Live, fully interactive preview inside the station editor
- Multi-station switching panel that slides up inside the player
- Pop-out player in a compact floating window
- Full-width sticky player docked to the top or bottom of the page

Built right

- No telemetry, no tracking, no API keys and no premium tier
- No CDN dependencies — HLS.js is bundled locally
- Player CSS and JavaScript load only on pages that contain a shortcode
- Self-hosted, cache-proof automatic updates delivered from GitHub

SECTION 3

Requirements & installation

System requirements

Requirement	Minimum	Notes
WordPress	5.2 or later	Tested up to WordPress 6.8
PHP	7.2 or later	PHP 8.x fully supported
Browser	Modern evergreen	Chrome, Firefox, Safari, Edge

Installing from a ZIP file

1. In the WordPress admin, go to **Plugins** → **Add New** → **Upload Plugin**.
2. Click **Choose File** and select the plugin ZIP.
3. Click **Install Now**, then **Activate Plugin**.
4. A new **Radio Stations** menu item will appear in the admin sidebar.

After activation

Activation registers a custom post type called **Radio Stations**. Each station you create is a single post with its own settings and its own shortcode. You are ready to build your first station.

Automatic updates

Once activated, the plugin checks for new versions automatically and delivers them straight to your WordPress **Plugins** screen — no marketplace account required. Updates are served from a GitHub-hosted manifest, so they are reliable and unaffected by aggressive host caching.

SECTION 4

Quick start

Your first station in five minutes

1. Go to **Radio Stations** → **Add New**.
2. Enter a **station name** — this is used as the player title.
3. Choose a **Player Mode**: *Live Stream* or *File Player*.
4. For Live Stream, paste your **stream URL**. For File Player, click **Choose** to add tracks from the Media Library.
5. Optionally set a **Featured Image** to use as station artwork.
6. Pick a **skin** and adjust colours in the Player Appearance panel — watch the live preview update as you go.
7. Click **Publish**.
8. Copy the shortcode from the **Shortcode** panel and paste it into any page, post or widget.

The everyday shortcode

Placing a player is as simple as dropping its shortcode into your content. Each station has a unique numeric ID, shown in the Shortcode panel on its edit screen:

```
[mbr_radio_player id="123"]
```

Replace 123 with your own station ID. That is all that is needed for a fully working player.

SECTION 5

Creating a station

Every player begins life as a **Radio Station** post. The edit screen collects everything the player needs, grouped into clearly labelled panels.

Station Details

- **Title** — shown as the player heading and used as the accessible label.
- **Player Mode** — a toggle between *Live Stream* and *File Player*. The rest of the panel changes to match your choice.
- **Stream URL** (Live Stream mode) — the address of your internet radio stream.
- **Tracks** (File Player mode) — one or more audio files chosen from the Media Library.

Featured Image (artwork)

Set a WordPress **Featured Image** to give the player station artwork. It appears beside the controls and, in multi-station setups, updates as the listener switches stations. Artwork is optional — the player looks clean without it.

Player Appearance

Choose a skin, toggle dark mode or glassmorphism, and — on the Default skin — pick your two gradient colours. See Section 8 for the full appearance reference.

Station Group (optional)

Select other stations here to build a switcher. A station-switching panel then appears inside the player automatically. See Section 11.

Shortcode

Once published, this panel shows the ready-to-copy shortcode for the station, including its unique ID.

SECTION 6

Live Stream mode

Live Stream mode connects the player to an internet radio stream. Once configured, it displays live now-playing metadata, a real-time status indicator, and — where several stations are grouped — seamless station switching.

Setting it up

1. Set **Player Mode** to *Live Stream*.
2. Paste your stream address into the **Stream URL** field.
3. Publish and place the shortcode.

What listeners see

- A play / pause control and volume slider
- A live status indicator showing whether the stream is connected
- A now-playing metadata marquee, where the stream provides it (ICY / Icecast metadata)
- A pop-out button to open the stream in a floating window

Supported stream types

HLS (.m3u8) adaptive streams, Shoutcast (.m3u playlists, with automatic stream-URL detection), Icecast (with full ICY metadata), and direct MP3, AAC and OGG streams. Services such as BBC Radio (HLS) and SomaFM (MP3/AAC) work out of the box.

A note on metadata

Now-playing text is supplied by the stream itself. If a station does not broadcast ICY/Icecast metadata, the marquee simply stays quiet — the audio still plays perfectly. This is a property of the stream, not the player.

SECTION 7

File Player mode

File Player mode turns the player into a full-featured audio file player. Upload one or more files from the Media Library and the player gains a progress bar, seek scrubbing, skip controls, an auto-advancing playlist and resume-from-position.

Adding tracks

1. Set **Player Mode** to *File Player*.
2. Click **Choose** to open the Media Library (filtered to audio files).
3. Select one or more files. They appear as a numbered playlist.
4. Drag tracks to reorder them. The order is saved with the station.

Playback controls

- **Progress bar** with click-to-seek and touch scrubbing
- **Rewind 15s** and **Forward 15s** buttons
- **Auto-advance** to the next track when one finishes
- A slide-up **track list panel** for jumping between files

Resume from last position

While a file plays, the listener's position is saved to their browser's localStorage every five seconds. When they return and press play, the player seeks straight back to where they were — even after closing the browser. The saved position is cleared automatically once a track plays to the end, so the next listen starts fresh.

Recommended file format

Any format the visitor's browser supports natively will work: MP3, AAC/M4A, OGG/Vorbis, FLAC, WAV and WebM audio. **MP3 has the widest cross-browser support and is recommended** for public-facing playlists.

SECTION 8

Player appearance & skins

The six skins

Skin	Character
Default	Modern gradient player with a fully customisable two-colour picker
Classic	Clean, traditional player styling
Gradient Dark	Rich dark gradient for low-light and night themes
Minimal	Pared-back, understated controls that recede into the page
Retro	Characterful, nostalgic styling with personality
Slim Bar	Compact single-row bar, ideal for tight spaces and headers

Colours & effects

- **Custom gradient** — on the Default skin, choose any two colours and the player blends between them.
- **Dark mode** — a darker treatment that suits dark page designs.
- **Glassmorphism** — a frosted, translucent finish that lets the background show through.
- **Artwork** — the station's featured image is shown alongside the controls.

Override the skin per placement

The main shortcode accepts an optional `skin` attribute, letting you use a different skin for a particular placement without changing the station's saved setting:

```
[mbr_radio_player id="123" skin="minimal"]
```

Valid skin values are: `default`, `classic`, `gradient-dark`, `minimal`, `retro` and `slim-bar`.

SECTION 9

The live admin preview

One of the plugin's most useful features is the live preview built into the station editor. Every change you make is reflected instantly in the preview panel, so you always know exactly what visitors will see before you publish.

The preview updates for

- Skin selection and colour changes
- Dark mode and glassmorphism toggles
- Station artwork
- Title edits
- Tracks being added, removed, reordered, or picked from the Media Library (File Player mode)
- The Player Mode toggle itself

It really plays

The preview player is fully interactive. You can press play and hear your stream or your files directly inside the admin — no need to publish and open the front end just to check the sound.

SECTION 10

Shortcode reference

The plugin registers two shortcodes. In almost all cases you only need the first.

Standard player

```
[mbr_radio_player id="123"]  
[mbr_radio_player id="123" skin="gradient-dark"]
```

Attribute	Required	Description
<code>id</code>	Yes	The numeric ID of the Radio Station post to display
<code>skin</code>	No	Overrides the station's saved skin for this placement only

Sticky player

```
[mbr_radio_player_sticky id="123"]
```

Attribute	Required	Description
<code>id</code>	Yes	The numeric ID of the station to dock as a full-width sticky bar

Where to place shortcodes

Standard players sit anywhere in your content — pages, posts, or widget areas. The sticky player is usually added once, site-wide, via a header or footer widget area or theme template, so it is available on every page. See Section 13.

SECTION 11

Multi-station switching

If you run several stations, you can group them so that a single player offers a station switcher. Listeners tap to move between streams without the page reloading.

Setting up a group

1. Open the station that will act as the main player.
2. In the **Station Group** panel, select the other stations to include.
3. Update or publish the station.
4. A station-switching panel now slides up inside that player automatically.

Artwork follows the station

When a listener switches station, the player updates the now-playing details and the station artwork to match the newly selected stream — all without leaving the page.

Mixing modes

Grouped stations can be a mix of Live Stream and File Player stations. Each station keeps its own configuration; the group simply provides the switcher UI.

SECTION 12

Pop-out player

Every stream player includes a pop-out button. Clicking it opens the station in a compact floating window, so listeners can keep the audio going while they browse the rest of your site — or even other sites entirely.

How it behaves

- Opens a small, dedicated player window
- Playback continues uninterrupted while the listener navigates away
- Closing the window stops that playback
- Requires no configuration — it is always available on stream players

Great for engagement

The pop-out is ideal for radio and podcast sites where you want listeners to keep the audio on while they read articles, browse the schedule, or explore your archive.

SECTION 13

Sticky player

The sticky player is a full-width bar that docks to the top or bottom of the browser window and stays put as the visitor scrolls. It keeps audio controls permanently within reach.

Adding it

Place the sticky shortcode where you want it to load — typically once, site-wide, via a widget area or theme template:

```
[mbr_radio_player_sticky id="123"]
```

Behaviour

- **Full browser width**, docked top or bottom
- **Close button** — visitors can dismiss it at any time; closing pauses playback
- **Never auto-starts** — playback begins only when the listener presses play, respecting browser autoplay policies
- **Includes the pop-out button** for separate-window playback
- **Responsive** — the volume slider hides on narrow screens and controls stay touch-friendly

Position tip

The bottom position is generally the least intrusive and works well for most sites. The top position suits news and radio sites where constant, prominent access is expected. It inherits your station's dark-mode, glassmorphism and colour settings.

SECTION 14

Supported formats

Live streams

Format	Notes
HLS (.m3u8)	Adaptive bitrate streaming; used by BBC Radio and many broadcasters
Shoutcast	.m3u playlists with automatic stream-URL detection
Icecast	Full ICY metadata support for now-playing information
MP3 / AAC / OGG	Direct stream URLs in any browser-native audio format

File Player audio files

Format	Support
MP3	Widest cross-browser support — recommended
AAC / M4A	Broad support across modern browsers
OGG / Vorbis	Supported where the browser allows it
FLAC / WAV / WebM	Play natively in browsers that support the codec

HLS everywhere

Safari plays HLS natively. For Chrome, Firefox and Edge, the plugin bundles HLS.js locally and loads it only when an HLS stream is present — so HLS works consistently across browsers with no external dependency.

SECTION 15

Frequently asked questions

Does it work with BBC Radio, SomaFM and similar services?

Yes. Full HLS support handles BBC Radio and any other HLS stream, and MP3/AAC streams from services such as SomaFM work natively.

Can I have multiple stations?

Yes — create as many as you need. Each station has its own shortcode and can be placed independently.

Can I use File Player and Live Stream on the same site?

Yes. Each station is configured independently, so some can stream live while others play hosted files, all on the same site.

Does it slow down my site?

No. Player CSS and JavaScript load only on pages that contain a player shortcode, and HLS.js is loaded only when an HLS stream is present.

Does it require any external services?

No external services, no CDN, no tracking and no API keys. Everything runs within your WordPress installation.

Can I customise the player colours?

Yes. On the Default skin you can choose any two gradient colours, and six alternative pre-designed skins are also available.

How does resume-from-position work?

While a listener plays a file, their position is saved to localStorage every five seconds and restored on their next play. It is cleared automatically when a track finishes, so the next listen starts from the beginning.

Is localStorage subject to GDPR?

localStorage is treated as persistent client-side storage under ePrivacy rules, similar to cookies. A resume-position feature like this generally falls under 'functional' storage, which is typically exempt from consent — but you should assess this against your own site and applicable regulations.

SECTION 16

Troubleshooting

The player shows 'Please provide a valid radio station ID'

The shortcode is missing its `id` attribute, or the ID does not match a published station. Copy the exact shortcode from the station's Shortcode panel.

Audio will not start until I press play

This is expected and intentional. Browsers block autoplay of sound, so the player always waits for a deliberate play action from the listener.

No now-playing text appears on a live stream

Now-playing metadata is supplied by the stream. If the station does not broadcast ICY/Icecast metadata, the marquee stays empty while the audio plays normally.

A file will not play in a particular browser

That browser may not support the file's codec. MP3 is the safest choice for the widest compatibility; try re-encoding the file to MP3.

Appearance changes are not showing on the front end

If your site uses page or object caching, clear it after saving so visitors receive the updated markup and styles.

An HLS stream plays in Safari but not elsewhere

HLS.js loads only when an HLS stream is detected. Confirm the stream URL ends in `.m3u8` and is reachable; other browsers rely on the bundled HLS.js to play it.

SECTION 17

Privacy, data & performance

What the plugin does not do

- No telemetry or usage tracking of any kind
- No third-party CDNs — all assets are served from your own site
- No accounts, API keys or external service sign-ups
- No analytics or data sent anywhere by the plugin

Client-side storage

In File Player mode, the resume-from-position feature stores a small playback position value in the visitor's own browser using localStorage. This never leaves the visitor's device and is cleared automatically when a track completes. See the GDPR note in Section 15.

Performance

Player CSS and JavaScript are enqueued only on pages that actually contain a player shortcode, so the rest of your site is unaffected. HLS.js — the one bundled library — is loaded only when an HLS stream is present on the page.

Your data stays yours

Everything the plugin needs lives inside your WordPress installation. There is no external dependency for the plugin to function, which keeps your site fast, private and fully under your control.

SECTION 18

Third-party libraries

The plugin bundles a single third-party library, used only for stream playback.

HLS.js v1.4.12

Detail	Value
Purpose	Enables HLS (.m3u8) playback in browsers without native HLS support
Developer	video-dev (open source)
Licence	Apache License 2.0
Source	github.com/video-dev/hls.js
Privacy	Client-side only. Collects, stores and transmits no user data; connects only to the stream URLs you configure. No tracking or analytics.
Loading	Bundled locally and loaded only when an HLS stream is present. Safari uses native HLS and does not load it.

SECTION 19

Updates & support

Automatic updates

The plugin checks for new releases on its own and surfaces them on your WordPress **Plugins** screen, exactly like any other update. Version 3.9.27 delivers these updates via Plugin Update Checker 5.7 with the manifest served from GitHub, giving reliable, cache-proof update detection without a marketplace account.

Where to find help

- Plugin home and documentation: littlewebshack.com/radio
- Author: **Robert Palmer — Made by Robert** (madebyrobert.co.uk)

Enjoying the plugin?

MBR Live Radio Player is free and GPL-licensed, built and maintained by a single developer. If it has saved you time, a coffee is always appreciated — look for the 'Buy me a coffee' link on the plugin row on your Plugins screen. Thank you for using it.